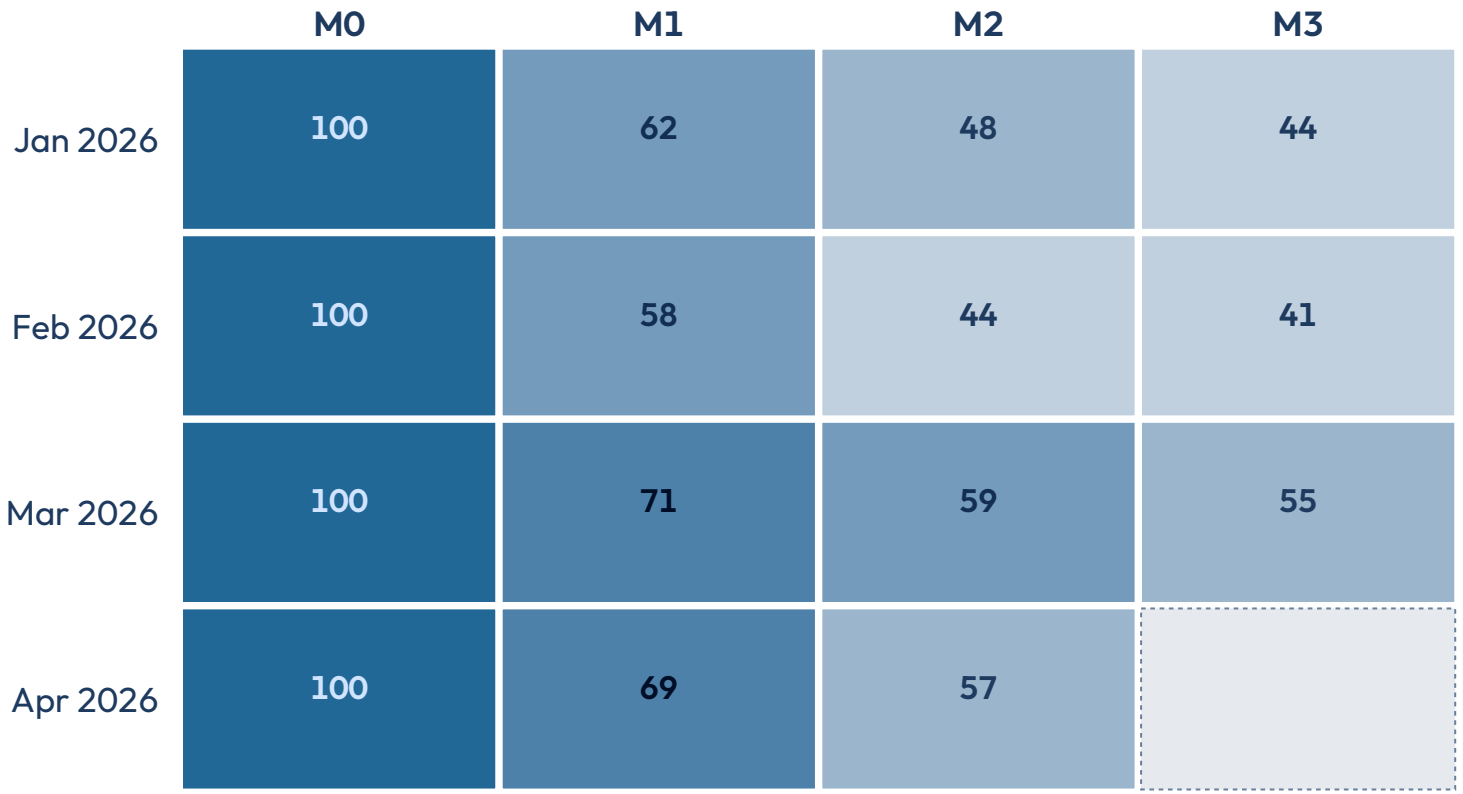
Evidence · Canvas · Series

heatmap

A numeric matrix read as intensity — where the value concentrates across two dimensions.

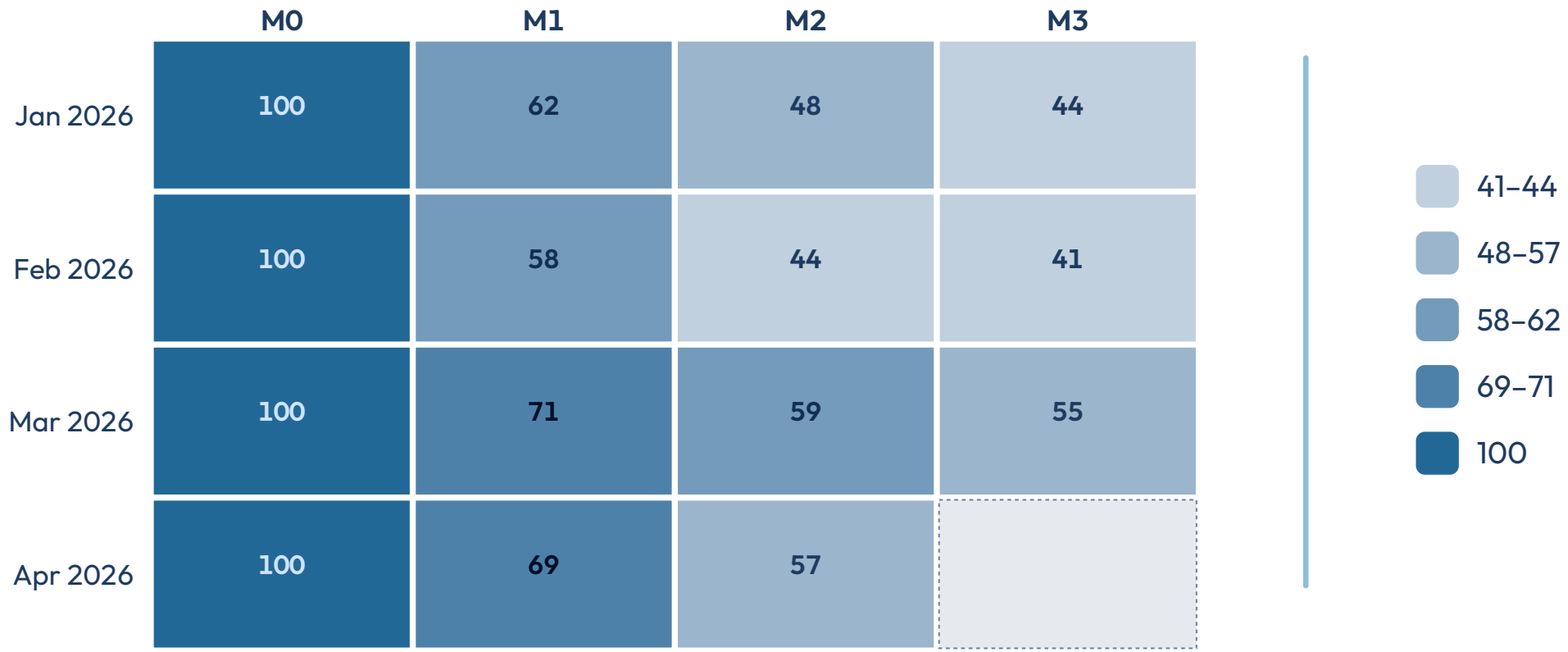
Retention · 2026 cohorts

Retention decays fastest in month two.



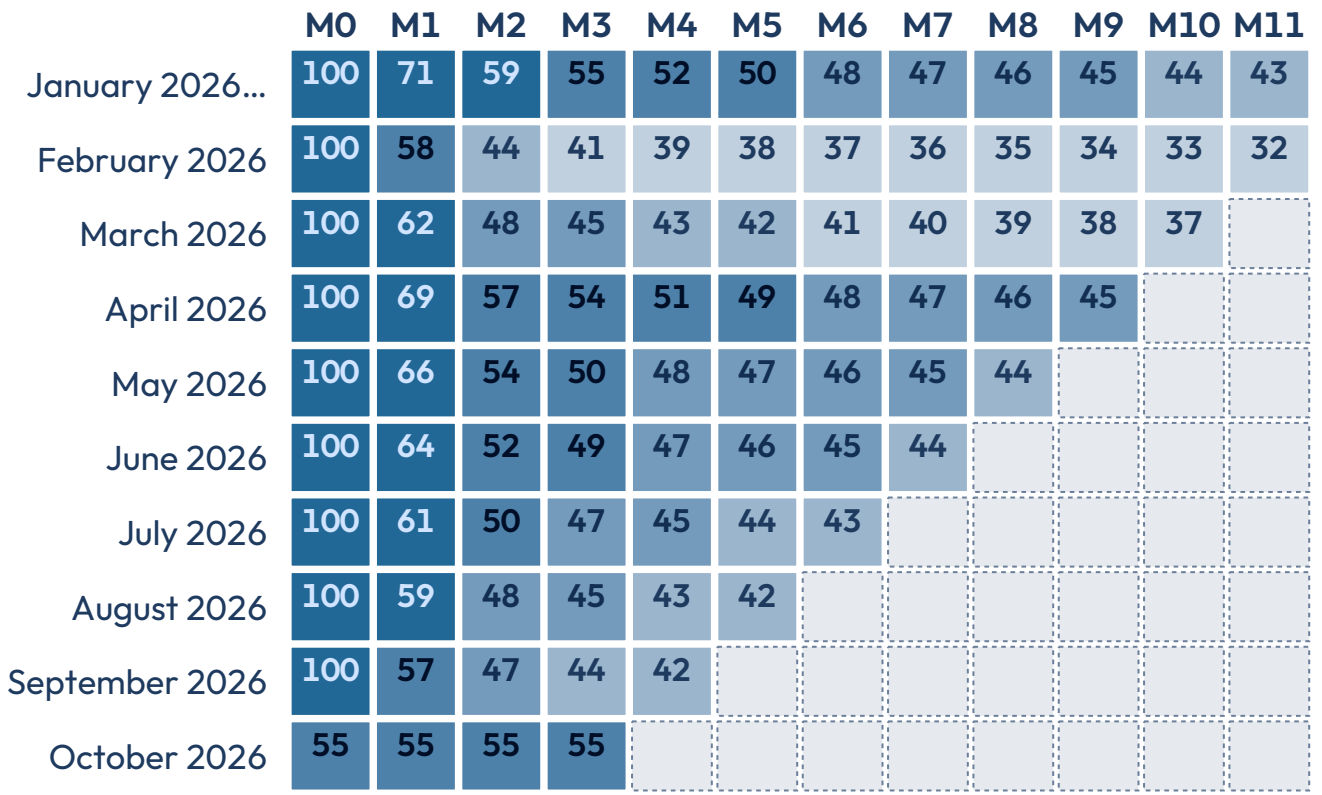
Retention · 2026 cohorts

The chart names its own bands.



Retention · the ceiling

Ten cohorts by twelve months — the density this holds.



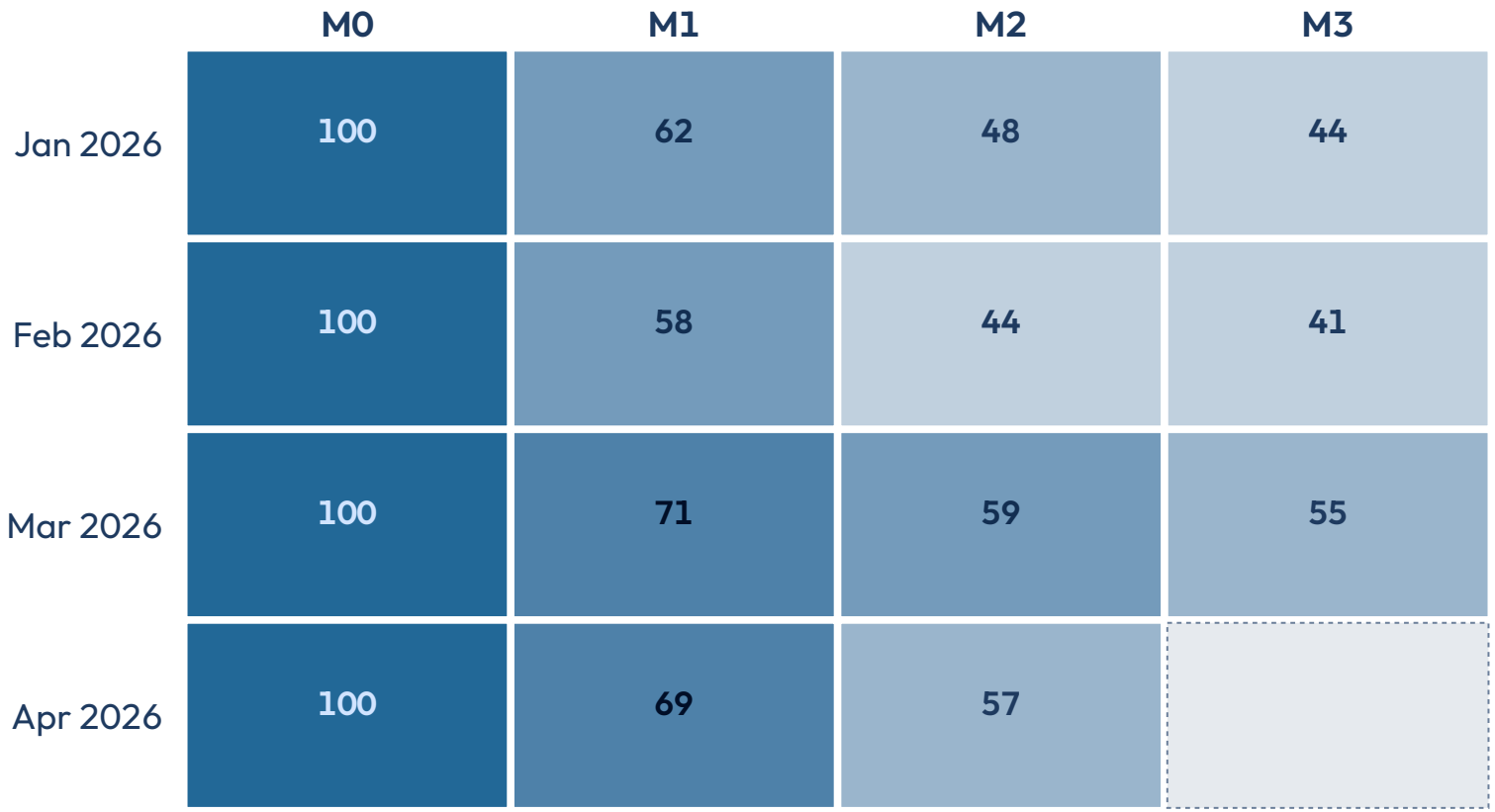
Retention · 2026 cohorts

Retention decays fastest in month two.

	M0	M1	M2	M3
Jan 2026	100	62	48	44
Feb 2026	100	58	44	41
Mar 2026	100	71	59	55
Apr 2026	100	69	57	

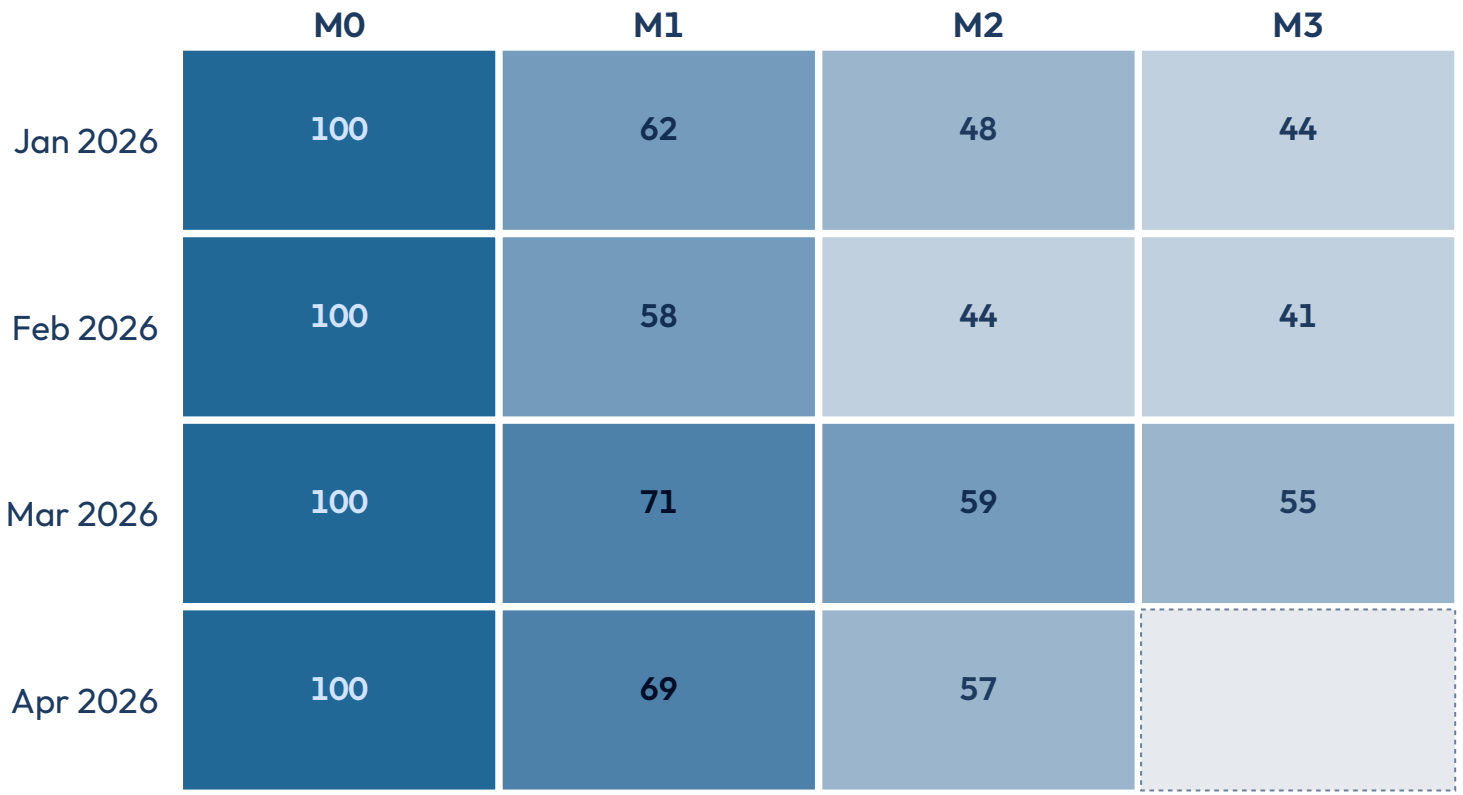
Retention · 2026 cohorts

Retention decays fastest in month two.



Retention · 2026 cohorts

Retention decays fastest in month two.



When NOT to reach for heatmap.

One row of numbers

A single series is not a matrix — it is a comparison, and a reader judges length far more precisely than intensity. Use `bar`. The kernel declines a one-column table for this reason rather than painting a single strip.

Qualitative cells

If the cells are verbs, owners or statuses rather than numbers, the ramp has nothing to encode. Use `matrix-grid`, whose cells are tagged at parse time.

When NOT to reach for heatmap.

Precise comparison

Asking a reader which of two similar cells is larger spends the one thing intensity is bad at, and the five-tone binning above makes it stricter: two cells in the same band are the same color by design. If the comparison has to be exact, the value belongs on an axis — `bar` or `line`.

Geography

A value per country or region belongs on the `map` choropleth, which shares this ramp but places the cells where the reader expects them.

Related components

See also.

`matrix-grid` — the cells are qualitative — a verb, an owner, a status — rather than a number

`map` — the two dimensions are geographic; same ramp, spatial placement

`bar` — one dimension, and the comparison has to be exact

`quadrant` — two CONTINUOUS axes with items placed on them, rather than two categorical axes with a value at each crossing